



P47 · 30 PAGES, PRINTABLE + FILLABLE

Stay-at-Home Parent Transition Planner

A thirty-page planner for the transition from paid work to staying home with kids. The financial conversation with the partner. The retirement + own-money page that most planners skip. The "what if we split" honest planning. The day-shape design. The friend network to rebuild. The eventual re-entry plan, if you want one. With pages for the identity loss that does not get talked about.

Soothemade **Notes**

A SMALL APOTHECARY OF PRINTABLES · MADE SLOWLY

A note before you start

You are leaving paid work to stay home. Or you have already left. Or you are about to.

The transition gets congratulated. It gets framed as “lucky” by the people still in offices. It gets framed as a “real job” by the people who have already done it. Both are partially true and neither is helpful for the actual planning.

What needs to be planned for is the money. The retirement account. The identity. The day-shape. The friend network that quietly disappears when you no longer share a hallway with people. The eventual re-entry, when and if you want one.

This planner is for the planning. It is not a feminist treatise. It is not a defense of the choice. The choice has been made or is being made by you and your family for your reasons. The planner does the work that comes after the choice.

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This is a planning tool, not financial or legal advice. The financial and legal aspects of this transition should be reviewed by a financial planner and, if relevant, an attorney. The mental-health pages list crisis lines. Stay-at-home parents have elevated rates of depression and isolation. Knowing this in advance helps you watch for it.

How to use this planner

- Some pages are for you alone. Some are for the partner conversation.
- The “money” section, four pages, is meant to be done with the partner, not solo. Schedule a time. Bring food.
- The day-shape templates are by kid age. Find yours and start there.
- The re-entry section is at the back. You can ignore it for years. It is there for whenever it becomes relevant.

The "I am still a person" page

A page to come back to.

PERMISSION SLIPS

You are still a person.

You did not become "just the mom" or "just the dad" the day you left your job.

Your work history did not get erased when you stopped showing up at the office.

Your interests, your sense of humor, your taste in music, the things that bored you in meetings, the way you say "actually" before you disagree with someone, all of those are still here.

You also are a parent, primarily, for these years. That part is real.

The work is holding both at once.

The next 30 pages help you do that.

WRITE DOWN, RIGHT NOW, THREE THINGS ABOUT YOU THAT HAVE NOTHING TO DO WITH BEING A PARENT

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

KEEP THIS PAGE. COME BACK TO IT.

The partner money conversation, part 1: joint

This page is meant to be done with the partner. Schedule the time. It takes more than 15 minutes.

THE JOINT NUMBER

Our combined monthly income, with one of us not earning:

Our monthly essential expenses (rent / mortgage, utilities, food, insurance, kids):

The gap (positive or negative):

How long can the gap be sustained, if negative:

What we cut if needed:

THE JOINT ACCOUNT VS PERSONAL ACCOUNT QUESTION

How do we want to handle money in this new arrangement?

- ☐ One joint account, everything goes in and out
- ☐ Mostly joint, with personal accounts for personal spending
- ☐ Separate accounts with a shared bill-paying account
- ☐ Something else: _____

How much "no-questions-asked" personal money does each of us have, monthly?

The staying-home parent gets: \$____

The working parent gets: \$____

(These should not be wildly different. If they are, talk about why.)

What counts as "personal" vs "household"?

The partner money conversation, part 2: retirement

This is the page most planners skip.

WHEN ONE OF YOU STOPS EARNING, ONE OF YOU STOPS GETTING TAX-ADVANTAGED RETIREMENT CONTRIBUTIONS FROM EMPLOYMENT.

IF THIS IS NOT ADDRESSED, THE STAYING-HOME PARENT'S RETIREMENT ACCOUNT QUIETLY STAGNATES FOR THE YEARS THEY ARE HOME.

OPTIONS TO CONSIDER (with a financial planner, not just reading this)

- ☐ Spousal IRA: in many places, the working spouse can contribute to an IRA in the staying-home spouse's name. Check the current rules with a financial planner.
- ☐ Increased contributions to the working spouse's retirement account that are mentally earmarked for the household.
- ☐ Joint brokerage or investment accounts that grow during this period.
- ☐ Other tax-advantaged vehicles depending on your country.

THE NUMBER THE STAYING-HOME PARENT IS COMFORTABLE WITH

How much per month / year is being contributed to retirement on the staying-home parent's behalf?

\$_____

The financial planner I am talking to about this:

Name: _____
Phone: _____
Meeting date: _____

A NOTE: WOMEN AND OTHER PRIMARY CAREGIVERS HISTORICALLY ARRIVE AT RETIREMENT WITH MEANINGFULLY LESS THAN PARTNERS WHO WORKED CONTINUOUSLY. THIS IS NOT INEVITABLE. IT IS A PRODUCT OF THE CHOICES NOT BEING ACTIVELY MADE. MAKE THE CHOICES.

The partner money conversation, part 3: the “what if we split”

A planning page, not a pessimism page. Couples who plan for this stay married more, statistically, because the planning surfaces problems that otherwise simmer.

THE HONEST QUESTIONS

If we separated five years from now, what would the staying-home parent be left with, financially?

What would the working parent be left with?

Are those balanced? ☐ Yes ☐ No (this is worth fixing)

What would the custody arrangement look like, ballpark?

WHAT WE WOULD WANT, IF IT HAPPENED

The staying-home parent:

The working parent:

THE PRE-EMPTIVE PROTECTIONS

- ☐ Both names on the deed of the house
- ☐ Both names on major investment accounts
- ☐ Wills are updated
- ☐ Beneficiaries are reviewed
- ☐ Life insurance is in place for both adults (often missed for the stay-home spouse, but their economic value is enormous if they are gone)
- ☐ Disability insurance is in place
- ☐ Long-term-care insurance considered
- ☐ Spousal IRA or equivalent is funded

THE ATTORNEY OR PLANNER I AM CONFIRMING THIS WITH

A REMINDER: HAVING THIS CONVERSATION DOES NOT MEAN YOU ARE PLANNING TO SEPARATE. IT MEANS YOU ARE PLANNING NOT TO BE STRANDED IF SOMETHING HAPPENS, INCLUDING DEATH OR DISABILITY, NOT JUST DIVORCE.

The partner money conversation, part 4: when it goes back

If or when the staying-home parent goes back to paid work.

THE RE-ENTRY CONVERSATION

Are we both clear that this stay-home stretch is open-ended / indefinite / time-bound?

What is the current loose timeline?

What would trigger the re-entry conversation sooner?

What would extend it longer than the current plan?

WHEN THE RE-ENTRY HAPPENS, WE WILL NEED TO

- ☐ Cover childcare (the cost can equal a significant portion of a new salary, this needs to be planned for, not surprised by)
- ☐ Negotiate the household-work split anew
- ☐ Update retirement / savings goals
- ☐ Consider tax implications

A NOTE: THE STAYING-HOME PARENT'S RE-ENTRY IS NOT JUST THEIR DECISION. IT IS A FAMILY DECISION. THE WORKING PARENT MAY HAVE OPINIONS, AND THOSE OPINIONS ARE WORTH HEARING, BUT THE DECISION ABOUT WHEN TO RE-ENTER IS PRIMARILY THE STAYING-HOME PARENT'S TO MAKE.

The “what is my work now” reframe

A page for the days when the question “what do you do” feels harder than it used to.

THE OLD ANSWER

Before, I would say:

THE PROBLEM WITH "I AM A STAY-AT-HOME MOM/DAD"

It is true, but it does not describe the work. It is also a shorthand that often invites:

- The "oh, lucky you" reaction
- The "must be nice" reaction
- The condescending "what a wonderful gift to your kids" reaction
- The "I could never do that" reaction

None of those are conversations. They are conversation enders.

A FEW OTHER ANSWERS TO TRY

- "I am running a small operation from my house."
- "I am at home with the kids for a few years."
- "I do the family logistics."
- "I am between roles right now and managing the home."

PRACTICE WHAT I WANT TO SAY NEXT TIME

WHAT I AM ACTUALLY DOING, IN PLAIN WORDS

On a Tuesday, I:

That is real work. Write it down so you remember it on the days you forget.

THE LIST OF SKILLS I AM USING DAILY

- Logistics (calendar, supplies, planning)
- Conflict mediation (kid arguments, partner-and-me)
- Project management (meal prep, household systems)
- Crisis response (illnesses, behavior, weather)
- Negotiation (with kids, with partner, with self)
- Budgeting
- Emotional labor coordination
- Childcare expertise specific to your kids

THESE ARE REAL SKILLS. THEY EXIST ON RESUMES UNDER OTHER NAMES.
THEY DO NOT DISAPPEAR.

Day-shape design, infant

For the staying-home parent of a kid under 1.

THE GENERAL SHAPE OF AN INFANT DAY

Mornings, roughly:

- ____:____ Wake up + first feed
- ____:____ Breakfast for the adults
- ____:____ Morning nap (start)
- ____:____ Morning nap (end)
- ____:____ Activity / walk / play
- ____:____ Lunch + second feed

Afternoon:

- ____:____ Afternoon nap (start)
- ____:____ Afternoon nap (end)
- ____:____ Afternoon walk or outing
- ____:____ Dinner prep

Evening:

- ____:____ Dinner
- ____:____ Bath
- ____:____ Last feed
- ____:____ Bedtime (kid)
- ____:____ Time as a couple, or time alone, or sleep

THE NAP WINDOWS I AM RELYING ON FOR MY OWN TIME

Length of the morning nap, on a good day: _____

Length of the afternoon nap: _____

What I want to do in those windows:

- ☐ Sleep / rest
- ☐ Shower
- ☐ Eat a real meal
- ☐ Read or hobby
- ☐ Connect with friends
- ☐ Errand / household task
- ☐ Plan for tomorrow

ONE TIME PER WEEK WHEN I AM NOT ON DUTY (handed off)

When: _____

What I will do: _____

Day-shape design, toddler

For the staying-home parent of a kid 1-3.

THE GENERAL SHAPE OF A TODDLER DAY

Morning:

- ____:____ Wake up
- ____:____ Breakfast
- ____:____ Get dressed
- ____:____ First-half outing (park, library, errand)
- ____:____ Snack
- ____:____ Lunch

Afternoon:

- ____:____ Nap (sacred, work around)
- ____:____ Wake from nap
- ____:____ Snack
- ____:____ Second-half outing or play
- ____:____ Dinner prep with toddler underfoot

Evening:

- ____:____ Dinner
- ____:____ Bath
- ____:____ Bedtime routine
- ____:____ Kid asleep
- ____:____ My evening

THE NAP IS YOUR OXYGEN

Toddler naps are usually 1-2 hours. Plan that window.

What I want to do during nap:

OUTINGS THAT WORK

- ☐ Library
- ☐ Park
- ☐ Grocery store
- ☐ Walk around neighborhood
- ☐ Friend's house with kid the same age
- ☐ Indoor play space (winter)
- ☐ Story time
- ☐ Errand that doubles as outing

WHEN I AM NOT ON DUTY THIS WEEK

Day-shape design, school-age

For the staying-home parent of a kid 4 and up, especially when they are in part-time or full-time school.

THE OPENING UP OF SCHOOL HOURS

Mornings:

__:__ Get up

__:__ School drop-off

The hours between drop-off and pickup:

__ to __ (this is your work window)

What I am doing with this stretch:

- ☐ Errands
- ☐ A part-time job or freelance work
- ☐ Volunteering
- ☐ Personal projects / hobbies / education
- ☐ Exercise
- ☐ Self-care / therapy / friend time
- ☐ Rest (also valid)

How I am dividing this stretch most days:

Pickup + afternoon:

__:__ Pickup

__:__ Snack

__:__ Homework / activities / play

The evening shape:

__:__ Dinner

__:__ Bath / quiet time

__:__ Bedtime

__:__ My evening

WHAT THIS PHASE OPENS UP THAT WAS NOT POSSIBLE BEFORE

This is the phase where many staying-home parents start re-entering work in some form. Worth planning for.

Friend network rebuilding

When you stop going to a job, you stop seeing the people from that job. The friend network from work fades faster than you expect.

THE OLD NETWORK

Friends from my old job who I want to stay connected to:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

What I will do to maintain those: (a monthly text, a quarterly call, a yearly lunch, whatever fits)

THE NEW NETWORK

Where to find other adults who are also staying home:

- ☐ Parent groups, in-person (library, community center, religious)
- ☐ Parent groups, online (Facebook, neighborhood apps)
- ☐ Mom/Dad meetups
- ☐ Stroller-friendly fitness groups
- ☐ Playgroups
- ☐ Online communities specific to your interests

The first person I will message this week to schedule a hangout:

The second person:

A NOTE: MAKING FRIENDS AS AN ADULT IS HARD. MAKING FRIENDS AS A STAYING-HOME PARENT IS HARDER BECAUSE THE CONNECTION OFTEN STARTS WITH "OUR KIDS ARE THE SAME AGE" AND HAS TO MATURE INTO "WE LIKE EACH OTHER." GIVE IT TIME. AIM FOR REGULAR LOW-EFFORT TIME WITH A FEW PEOPLE, NOT A BIG FRIEND GROUP IMMEDIATELY.

Social and professional identity outside parenting

The part-time work, the volunteer work, the hobby, the side project, the class, the thing that is yours.

WHAT I DID BEFORE THAT I WANT TO KEEP DOING

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

WHAT I HAVE ALWAYS WANTED TO TRY BUT NEVER HAD TIME FOR

THE LIST OF SMALL THINGS THAT ARE MINE

- ☐ A hobby I do weekly
- ☐ A book I am reading right now
- ☐ A class I am taking (online or in person)
- ☐ A side project
- ☐ A volunteer commitment
- ☐ A part-time freelance gig
- ☐ A friend group that does something together
- ☐ A monthly thing I do alone

THE NUMBER OF "MINE" THINGS I AM AIMING FOR

Goal: _____ items

Currently: _____ items

A REMINDER: THE STAYING-HOME PARENT WHO HAS NO IDENTITY OUTSIDE THE KIDS IS AT MEANINGFUL RISK OF DEPRESSION AND, EVENTUALLY, AT THE "WHO AM I WHEN THE KIDS LEAVE" CRISIS. BUILDING THE MINE-THINGS NOW, WHILE YOU ARE HOME, IS THE BEST INSURANCE AGAINST THAT.

Re-entry planning, when and how

This is the page you may come back to in months or years.

WHEN MIGHT I RE-ENTER

The age of the youngest kid that feels right to me: _____

The trigger that would make me re-enter sooner:

The trigger that would extend the at-home stretch:

WHAT KIND OF RE-ENTRY

- ☐ Same field as before, same level
- ☐ Same field as before, more flexible role
- ☐ Different field entirely
- ☐ Freelance or consulting
- ☐ Part-time first, then maybe full-time
- ☐ Education / re-skilling first, then job hunt
- ☐ Starting my own thing
- ☐ Hourly / shift work for income flexibility

THE GAP ON MY RESUME, IN PLAIN WORDS

How long am I planning to be home: _____ years

What will I do during that time that could go on a resume?

(Volunteer leadership. Freelance projects. Education.
Skill-building. Side projects. All of these count.)

THE NETWORK I WANT TO MAINTAIN FOR THE EVENTUAL RETURN

Former colleagues who would write me a reference:

Former bosses who would vouch for me:

Industry events I want to keep attending (even sporadically):

LinkedIn or equivalent that I want to keep updated:

A REMINDER: THE RESUME GAP IS LESS OF A BARRIER THAN IT USED TO BE. MANY EMPLOYERS NOW UNDERSTAND IT AS LEGITIMATE. THE BIGGEST RISK IS NOT THE GAP. IT IS THE STAYING-HOME PARENT DECIDING THEY ARE "UNHIREABLE" AND NOT APPLYING. THAT IS THE BARRIER.

The “I am not okay” page

Stay-at-home parents have elevated rates of depression, isolation, and at-home alcohol use. These are well-documented patterns. The planner names them honestly.

THE HONEST CHECK

How many days this past week did I:

- Get out of the house with the kid: _____
- Talk to an adult who is not my partner: _____
- Eat a meal sitting down at a table: _____
- Cry, beyond a few tears: _____
- Drink more than I usually would: _____
- Feel resentful of my partner specifically: _____
- Feel like "I am not built for this": _____
- Feel like myself, recognizably: _____

The pattern is concerning if:

- Get out of the house = 0 or 1
- Talk to an adult = 0 or 1
- Crying = 5+
- Drinking = 4+
- Resentful = 4+
- "Not built for this" = 4+
- Feel like myself = 0 or 1

WHAT I AM NOTICING IN MYSELF

WHO I COULD TELL

THE PROVIDER I AM RESERVING THE NUMBER FOR

My primary care: _____
A therapist: _____
A friend who has been through it: _____

CRISIS / SUPPORT LINES

US, 988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline

US, Postpartum Support International: 1-833-852-6262

(Note: still relevant up to a few years postpartum)

US, SAMHSA National Helpline (substance use, free, 24/7):

1-800-662-4357

UK, Samaritans: 116 123

Canada, 9-8-8 Suicide Crisis Helpline

Australia, Lifeline: 13 11 14

A NOTE: ASKING FOR HELP IS NOT FAILURE. STAYING HOME IS A REAL JOB,
AND REAL JOBS HAVE BURNOUT RATES. YOURS DOES TOO. THE PEOPLE WHO
HELP YOU ARE NOT JUDGING YOU. ANYONE WHO WOULD JUDGE YOU IS NOT
THE PERSON YOU CALL.

A final letter

You did something brave. You made a choice that is not easy to make.

The choice does not become easier on the page that says “made it.” It becomes a job. A job that has stretches of joy that no office can match and stretches of tedium and isolation that no office prepares you for.

The planner is one of the things keeping you honest, with yourself and with your partner. Use it. Update it. Bring it to a couples-therapy session if you are in one. Revisit the re-entry page every year, or every few years, even if you are not planning to go back yet.

What you are doing matters. It is also tiring, and it is also not the entirety of who you are. The fourth thing on the list, “the part of you that has nothing to do with being a parent,” is the part that will carry you through the long stretch. Tend it.

When the kids are grown, the planner is still here. The pages about you are still about you.

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Soothemade *Notes*

*Made for the version of you no one tells you about, the
one at four in the morning, the one in the parking lot, the
one who doesn't recognize her own week.*

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